an OBC DNA, implying that they form the bedrock of its support—there are indications that its rainbow coalition may be fraying at the edges. Over the decades, the BJP expanded its base to cover the Marathas, expanding the 'Madhav' acronym to 'Madhavam'. This, OBCs say, has led to them being shortchanged in favour of the better-off Marathas and the OBC quota being diluted on account of the state government's move to simplify the grant of Kunbi certificates to the Marathas.

In Wadigodri, Aniket Khatke says the OBCs are against the Marathas, who dominate the state's politics and the cooperative sector, being included in their category. Khatke, whose mother Kaveri is a candidate of Prakash Ambedkar's Vanchit Bahujan Aghadi from Ghansavangi in Jalna, accuses both alliances of double standards. "MVA leaders are fanning the Maratha protests, leading to *parakoticha jaatiwaad* (extreme casteism) while the BJP says it has an OBC DNA but will not stand with us. They are mollycoddling the Marathas at our cost," alleges Khatke. Indeed, the Mahayuti's attempts to placate Jarange-Patil and strike a balancing act between the OBC and Marathas has led to worries that it may fall between two stools.



"Everyone will abide by Maharashtra dharma. But who ordered the lathi charge against Jarange-Patil? Was it Shinde or Fadnavis?"

AADITYA THACKERAY *(MVA)*
Shiv Sena (UBT) leader

Sociopolitical analyst Somnath Gholve feels Jarange-Patil's impact would be less in the assembly poll due to factors like his volte face on contesting elections. But he feels in seats where two Marathas are in the fray, the community could back the MVA's Maratha nominee; where the MVA has no Maratha face, they could go with Shinde's Shiv Sena. "The MVA has an advantage in Marathwada," admits Gholve.

Marathwada's Pain Points

↘ Maratha vs OBC friction OBCs resent dominant Marathas' demand to be included in quotas meant for them

↘ Farmers' crisis The agrarian distress arising from low yields is now endemic. Low soybean, cotton prices have marginal farmers on edge

↘ Water woes Water is scarce for drinking and irrigation. Even cities like Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, Beed are parched

↘ Lack of industry There are very few factories beyond Aurangabad (Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar) to absorb the surplus manpower

↘ Distress migration Educated youngsters are forced to go to big cities for work. Mass migration of poor to western Maharashtra, other states to cut cane for sugar mills

↘ Costly higher education Private education is too costly and state-run professional colleges have too few seats. Maratha youth feel OBC status will boost their chances

↘ Govt jobs Public sector jobs are seen as lucrative and stable. This is also fuelling quota demands

This time, Marathwada will be tough to call due to multiple candidates in many seats, including more than one Maratha or OBC candidate and 'friendly fights' between allies, like at Ashti in Beed. Here, it's Maratha versus Maratha—the BJP has pitted Suresh Dhus against sitting MLA Balasaheb Ajabe of ally NCP (Ajit Pawar). Ex-BJP legislator Bhimrao Dhonde is the rebel candidate here. In Beed, there are two OBCs—MLA Sandeep Kshirsagar of the NCP (Sharadchandra Pawar) and his cousin Yogesh from Ajit's NCP—against three Maratha independents. In Parli, an OBC versus Maratha battle is on, with agriculture minister and Gopinath Munde's nephew Dhananjay Munde (NCP) taking on Rajesaheb Deshmukh of the NCP (SCP).

Social cleavages

In Mundewadi village in Beed, an informal economic boycott of each other by the Vanjari and Maratha communities has been on since the Lok Sabha election. It started after a Maratha allegedly posted defamatory content against BJP leader Pankaja Munde, daughter of the late deputy CM, who had lost to Bajrang Sonwane of the NCP(SCP) from Beed. The Mundes belong to the Vanjari caste, the dominant OBC grouping in Marathwada, while Sonwane is a Maratha. This made it a grudge match and led to stone-pelting between the two groups in Nandurghat, some 10 km from Mundewadi. Fire-fighting by the police and local administration ensured that normalcy was restored, but the peace is tenuous. "Even today, many of us do not give our custom to businesses owned by Marathas," says Baban Gholve from Mundewadi, blaming it on the "*jaatiwad* (casteism)" of the latter.

Regardless of the way in which Marathwada and Maharashtra vote, the tremors of this social strife will be felt for years. Villagers in Mundewadi claim that caste consciousness has seeped deep into young minds; Maratha and OBC students now do not mingle in classrooms or playgrounds. As Gholve says with some pain, it will take at least a generation or two to put this bitterness behind them. ■